

When they arrived at the Gare de Lyon she was glad to get out and walk up and down the platform. The keen cold air was refreshing after the steam-heated train. She observed with a smile that her friend of the mink coat was solving the possible awkwardness of the dinner problem in her own way. A dinner basket was being handed up and received through the window by the maid.

When the train started once more, and dinner was announced by a violent ringing of bells, Katherine went along to it much relieved in mind. Her *vis-à-vis* to-night was of an entirely different kind—a small man, distinctly foreign in appearance, with a rigidly waxed moustache and an egg-shaped head which he carried rather on one side. Katherine had taken in a book to dinner with her. She found the little man's eyes fixed upon it with a kind of twinkling amusement.

'I see, Madame, that you have a *roman policier*. You are fond of such things?'

'They amuse me,' Katherine admitted.

The little man nodded with the air of complete understanding.

'They have a good sale always, so I am told. Now why is that, eh, Mademoiselle? I ask it of you as a student of human nature—why should that be?'

Katherine felt more and more amused.

'Perhaps they give one the illusion of living an exciting life,' she suggested.

He nodded gravely.

'Yes, there is something in that.'

'Of course, one knows that such things don't really happen,' Katherine was continuing, but he interrupted her sharply.

'Sometimes, Mademoiselle! Sometimes! I who speak to you—they have happened to *me*.'

She threw him a quick, interested glance.

'Some day, who knows, *you* might be in the thick of things,' he went on. 'It is all chance.'

'I don't think it is likely,' said Katherine. 'Nothing of that kind ever happens to me.'

He leaned forward.

'Would you like it to?'

The question startled her, and she drew in her breath sharply.

'It is my fancy, perhaps,' said the little man, as he dexterously polished one of the forks, 'but I think that you have a yearning in you for interesting happenings. *Eh bien*, Mademoiselle, all through my life I have observed one thing—"All one wants one gets!" Who knows?' His face screwed itself up comically. 'You may get more than you bargain for.'

'Is that a prophecy?' asked Katherine, smiling as she rose from the table.

The little man shook his head.

'I never prophesy,' he declared pompously. 'It is true that I have the habit of being always right—but I do not boast of it. Good-night, Mademoiselle, and may you sleep well.'

Katherine went back along the train amused and entertained by her little neighbour. She passed the open door of her friend's compartment and saw the conductor making up the bed. The lady in the mink coat was standing looking out of the window. The second compartment, as Katherine saw through the communicating door, was empty, with rugs and bags heaped up on the seat. The maid was not there.

Katherine found her own bed prepared, and since she was tired, she went to bed and switched off her light about half-past nine.

She woke with a sudden start; how much time had passed she did not know. Glancing at her watch, she found that it had stopped. A feeling of intense uneasiness pervaded her and grew stronger moment by moment. At last she got up, threw her dressing-gown round her shoulders, and stepped out into the corridor. The whole train seemed wrapped in slumber. Katherine let down the window and sat by it for some minutes, drinking in the cool night air and trying vainly to calm her uneasy fears. She presently decided that she would go along to the end and ask the conductor for the right time so that she could set her watch. She found, however, that his little chair was vacant. She hesitated for a moment and then walked through into the next coach. She looked down the long, dim line of the corridor and saw, to her surprise, that a man was standing with his hand on the door of the compartment occupied by the lady in the mink coat. That is to say, she thought it was the compartment. Probably, however, she was mistaken. He stood there for a moment or two with his back to her, seeming uncertain and hesitating in his attitude. Then he

slowly turned, and with an odd feeling of fatality, Katherine recognized him as the same man whom she had noticed twice before—once in the corridor of the Savoy hotel and once in Cook's offices. Then he opened the door of the compartment and passed in, drawing it to behind him.

An idea flashed across Katherine's mind. Could this be the man of whom the other woman had spoken—the man she was journeying to meet.

Then Katherine told herself that she was romancing. In all probability she had mistaken the compartment.

She went back to her own carriage. Five minutes later the train slackened speed. There was the long plaintive hiss of the Westinghouse brake, and a few minutes later the train came to a stop at Lyons.

She got up. 'I am quite all right now. I suppose, really, I just needed some one to talk to. I can't think now why I have been making such an absolute fool of myself.'

Katherine got up too.

'I am so glad you feel better,' she said, trying to make her voice sound as conventional as possible. She was only too well aware that the aftermath of confidences is embarrassment. She added tactfully:

'I must be going back to my own compartment.'

She emerged into the corridor at the same time as the maid was also coming out from the next door. The latter looked towards Katherine, over her shoulder, and an expression of intense surprise showed itself on her face. Katherine turned also, but by that time whoever it was who had aroused the maid's interest had retreated into his or her compartment, and the corridor was empty. Katherine walked down it to regain her own place, which was in the next coach. As she passed the end compartment the door opened and a woman's face looked out for a moment and then pulled the door to sharply. It was a face not easily forgotten, as Katherine was to know when she saw it again. A beautiful face, oval and dark, very heavily made up in a bizarre fashion. Katherine had a feeling that she had seen it before somewhere.

She regained her own compartment without other adventure and sat for some time thinking of the confidence which had just been made to her. She wondered idly who the woman in the mink coat might be, wondered also how the end of her story would turn out.

'If I have stopped any one from making an idiot of themselves, I suppose I have done good work,' she thought to herself. 'But who knows? That is the kind of woman who is hard-headed and egotistical all her life, and it might be good for her to do the other sort of thing for a change. Oh, well—I don't suppose I shall ever see her again. She certainly won't want to see *me* again. That is the worst of letting people tell you things. They never do.'

She hoped that she would not be given the same place at dinner. She reflected, not without humour, that it might be awkward for both of them. Leaning back with her head against a cushion she felt tired and vaguely depressed. They had reached Paris, and the slow journey round the *cinture*, with its interminable stops and waits, was very wearisome.

were young, and we were thrust apart most brutally and unjustly. Now we have come together again.'

'Yes?'

'I—I am going to meet him now. Oh! I dare say you think it is all wrong, but you don't know the circumstances. My husband is impossible. He has treated me disgracefully.'

'Yes,' said Katherine again.

'What I feel so badly about is this. I have deceived my father—it was he who came to see me off at Victoria to-day. He wishes me to divorce my husband, and, of course, he has no idea—that I am going to meet this other man. He would think it extraordinarily foolish.'

'Well, don't you think it is?'

'I—I suppose it is.'

Ruth Kettering looked down at her hands; they were shaking violently.

'But I can't draw back now.'

'Why not?'

'I—it is all arranged, and it would break his heart.'

'Don't you believe it,' said Katherine robustly; 'hearts are pretty tough.'

'He will think I have no courage, no strength of purpose.'

'It seems to me an awfully silly thing that you are going to do,' said Katherine. 'I think you realize that yourself.'

Ruth Kettering buried her face in her hands. 'I don't know—I don't know. Ever since I left Victoria I have had a horrible feeling of something—something that is coming to me very soon—that I can't escape.'

She clutched convulsively at Katherine's hand.

'You must think I am mad talking to you like this, but I tell you I know something horrible is going to happen.'

'Don't think it,' said Katherine; 'try to pull yourself together. You could send your father a wire from Paris, if you like, and he would come to you at once.'

The other brightened.

'Yes, I could do that. Dear old Dad. It is queer—but I never knew until to-day how terribly fond of him I am.' She sat up and dried her eyes with a handkerchief. 'I have been very foolish. Thank you so much for letting me talk to you. I don't know why I got into such a queer, hysterical state.'

Chapter 11

Murder

KATHERINE wakened the next morning to brilliant sunshine. She went along to breakfast early, but met none of her acquaintances of the day before. When she returned to her compartment it had just been restored to its day-time appearance by the conductor, a dark man with a drooping moustache and melancholy face.

'Madame is fortunate,' he said; 'the sun shines. It is always a great disappointment to passengers when they arrive on a grey morning.'

'I should have been disappointed, certainly,' said Katherine.

The man prepared to depart.

'We are rather late, Madame,' he said. 'I will let you know just before we get to Nice.'

Katherine nodded. She sat by the window, entranced by the sunlit panorama. The palm trees, the deep blue of the sea, the bright yellow mimosa came with all the charm of novelty to the woman who for fourteen years had known only the drab winters of England.

When they arrived at Cannes, Katherine got out and walked up and down the platform. She was curious about the lady in the mink coat, and looked up at the windows of her compartment. The blinds were still drawn down—the only ones to be so on the whole train. Katherine wondered a little, and when she re-entered the train she passed along the corridor and noticed that these two compartments were still shuttered and closed. The lady of the mink coat was clearly no early riser.

Presently the conductor came to her and told her that in a few minutes the train would arrive at Nice. Katherine handed him a tip; the man thanked her, but still lingered. There was something odd about him. Katherine, who had at first wondered whether the tip had not been big

enough, was now convinced that something far more serious was amiss. His face was of a sickly pallor, he was shaking all over, and looked as if he had been frightened out of his life. He was eyeing her in a curious manner. Presently he said abruptly: 'Madame will excuse me, but is she expecting friends to meet her at Nice?'

'Probably,' said Katherine. 'Why?'

But the man merely shook his head and murmured something that Katherine could not catch and moved away, not reappearing until the train came to rest at the station, when he started handing her belongings down from the window.

Katherine stood for a moment or two on the platform rather at a loss, but a fair young man with an ingenuous face came up to her and said rather hesitatingly:

'Miss Grey, is it not?'

Katherine said that it was, and the young man beamed upon her seraphically and murmured:

'I am Chubby, you know—Lady Tamplin's husband. I expect she mentioned me, but perhaps she forgot. Have you got your *billet de baggage*? I lost mine when I came out this year, and you would not believe the fuss they made about it. Regular French red tape!'

Katherine produced it, and was just about to move off beside him when a very gentle and insidious voice murmured in her ear:

'A little moment, Madame, if you please.'

Katherine turned to behold an individual who made up for insignificance of stature by a large quantity of gold lace and uniform. The individual explained. 'There were certain formalities. Madame would perhaps be so kind as to accompany him. The regulations of the police—' He threw up his arms. 'Absurd, doubtless, but there it was.'

Mr Chubby Evans listened with a very imperfect comprehension, his French being of a limited order.

'So like the French,' murmured Mr Evans. He was one of those staunch patriotic Britons who, having made a portion of a foreign country their own, strongly resent the original inhabitants of it. 'Always up to some silly dodge or other. They've never tackled people on the station before, though. This is something quite new. I suppose you'll have to go.'

of the very rich of the earth. It was just an impression. I dare say I am wrong.'

'No,' said Ruth, 'you are not wrong.' She had suddenly become very grave. 'I wish you would tell me what other impressions you formed about me?'

'I—'

Ruth swept on disregarding the other's embarrassment.

'Oh, please, don't be conventional. I want to know. As we left Victoria I looked across at you, and I had the sort of feeling that you—well, understood what was going on in my mind.'

'I can assure you I am not a mind reader,' said Katherine, smiling.

'No; but will you tell me, please, just what you thought?' Ruth's eagerness was so intense and so sincere that she carried her point.

'I will tell you if you like, but you must not think me impertinent. I thought that for some reason you were in great distress of mind, and I was sorry for you.'

'You are right. You are quite right. I am in terrible trouble. I—I should like to tell you something about it, if I may.'

'Oh, dear,' Katherine thought to herself, 'how extraordinarily alike the world seems to be everywhere! People were always telling me things in St Mary Mead, and it is just the same thing here, and I don't really want to hear anybody's troubles!'

She replied politely:

'Do tell me.'

They were just finishing their lunch. Ruth gulped down her coffee, rose from her seat, and quite oblivious of the fact that Katherine had not begun to sip her coffee, said: 'Come to my compartment with me.'

They were two single compartments with a communicating door between them. In the second of them a thin maid, whom Katherine had noticed at Victoria, was sitting very upright on the seat, clutching a big scarlet morocco case with the initials R. V. K. on it. Mrs Kettering pulled the communicating door to and sank down on the seat. Katherine sat down beside her.

'I am in trouble and I don't know what to do. There is a man whom I am fond of—very fond of indeed. We cared for each other when we

thought all this out. She had decided of her own free will. What happiness had she ever had in her life up to now? She said to herself restlessly: 'Why shouldn't I be happy? No one will ever know.'

It seemed no time before Dover was reached. Ruth was a good sailor. She disliked the cold, and was glad to reach the shelter of the private cabin she had telegraphed for. Although she would not have admitted the fact, Ruth was in some ways superstitious. She was of the order of people to whom coincidence appeals. After disembarking at Calais and settling herself down with her maid in her double compartment in the Blue Train, she went along to the luncheon car. It was with a little shock of surprise that she found herself set down to a small table with, opposite her, the same woman who had been her *vis-à-vis* in the Pullman. A faint smile came to the lips of both women.

'This is quite a coincidence,' said Mrs Kettering.

'I know,' said Katherine; 'it is odd the way things happen.'

A flying attendant shot up to them with the wonderful velocity always displayed by the Compagnie Internationale des Wagons-Lits and deposited two cups of soup. By the time the omelette succeeded the soup they were chatting together in friendly fashion.

'It will be heavenly to get into the sunshine,' sighed Ruth.

'I am sure it will be a wonderful feeling.'

'You know the Riviera well?'

'No; this is my first visit.'

'Fancy that.'

'You go every year, I expect?'

'Practically. January and February in London are horrible.'

'I have always lived in the country. They are not very inspiring months there either. Mostly mud.'

'What made you suddenly decide to travel?'

'Money,' said Katherine. 'For ten years I have been a paid companion with just enough money of my own to buy myself strong country shoes; now I have been left what seems to me a fortune, though I dare say it would not seem so to you.'

'Now I wonder why you say that—that it would not seem so to me,' Katherine laughed. 'I don't really know. I suppose one forms impressions without thinking of it. I put you down in my own mind as one

Katherine departed with her guide. Somewhat to her surprise, he led her towards a siding where a coach of the departed train had been shunted. He invited her to mount into this, and, preceding her down the corridor, held aside the door of one of the compartments. In it was a pompous-looking official personage, and with him a nondescript being who appeared to be a clerk. The pompous-looking personage rose politely, bowed to Katherine, and said:

'You will excuse me, Madame, but there are certain formalities to be complied with. Madame speaks French, I trust?'

'Sufficiently, I think, Monsieur,' replied Katherine in that language.

'That is good. Pray be seated, Madame. I am M. Caux, the Commissary of Police.' He blew out his chest importantly, and Katherine tried to look sufficiently impressed.

'You wish to see my passport?' she inquired. 'Here it is.'

The Commissary eyed her keenly and gave a little grunt.

'Thank you, Madame,' he said, taking the passport from her. He cleared his throat. 'But what I really desire is a little information.'

'Information?'

The Commissary nodded his head slowly.

'About a lady who has been a fellow-passenger of yours. You lunched with her yesterday.'

'I am afraid I can't tell you anything about her. We fell into conversation over our meal, but she is a complete stranger to me. I have never seen her before.'

'And yet,' said the Commissary sharply, 'you returned to her compartment with her after lunch and sat talking for some time?'

'Yes,' said Katherine; 'that is true.'

The Commissary seemed to expect her to say something more. He looked at her encouragingly.

'Yes, Madame?'

'Well, Monsieur?' said Katherine.

'You can, perhaps, give me some kind of idea of that conversation?'

'I could,' said Katherine, 'but at the moment I see no reason to do so.' In somewhat British fashion she felt annoyed. This foreign official seemed to her impertinent.

'No reason?' cried the Commissary. 'Oh yes, Madame, I can assure you that there *is* a reason.'

'Then perhaps you will give it to me.'

The Commissary rubbed his chin thoughtfully for a minute or two without speaking.

'Madame,' he said at last, 'the reason is very simple. The lady in question was found dead in her compartment this morning.'

'Dead?' gasped Katherine. 'What was it—heart failure?'

'No,' said the Commissary in a reflective, dreamy voice. 'No—she was murdered.'

'Murdered!' cried Katherine.

'So you see, Madame, why we are anxious for any information we can possibly get.'

'But surely her maid—'

'The maid has disappeared.'

'Oh!' Katherine paused to assemble her thoughts.

'Since the conductor had seen you talking with her in her compartment, he quite naturally reported the fact to the police, and that is why, Madame, we have detained you, in the hope of gaining some information.'

'I am very sorry,' said Katherine. 'I don't even know her name.'

'Her name is Kettering. That we know from her passport and from the labels on her luggage. If we—'

There was a knock on the compartment door. M. Caux frowned. He opened it about six inches.

'What is the matter?' he said peremptorily. 'I cannot be disturbed.'

The egg-shaped head of Katherine's dinner acquaintance showed itself in the aperture. On his face was a beaming smile.

'My name,' he said, 'is Hercule Poirot.'

'Not,' the Commissary stammered, 'not *the* Hercule Poirot?'

'The same,' said M. Poirot. 'I remember meeting you once, M. Caux, at the *Shrété* in Paris, though doubtless you have forgotten me?'

'Not at all, Monsieur, not at all,' declared the Commissary heartily. 'But enter, I pray of you. You know of this—'

'Yes, I know,' said Hercule Poirot. 'I came to see if I might be of any assistance?'

desolation. There was a wild longing upon her to jump out of the train and to go back before it was too late. She, so calm, so self-assured, for the first time in her life felt like a leaf swept by the wind. If her father knew—what would he say?

Madness! Yes, just that, madness! For the first time in her life she was swept away by emotion, swept away to the point of doing a thing which even she knew to be incredibly foolish and reckless. She was enough Van Aldin's daughter to realize her own folly, and level headed enough to condemn her own action. But she was his daughter in another sense also. She had that same iron determination that would have what it wanted, and once it had made up its mind would not be balked. From her cradle she had been self-willed; the very circumstances of her life had developed that self-will in her. It drove her now remorselessly. Well, the die was cast. She must go through with it now.

She looked up, and her eyes met those of the woman sitting opposite. She had a sudden fancy that in some way this other woman had read her mind. She saw in those grey eyes understanding and—yes—compassion.

It was only a fleeting impression. The faces of both women hardened to well-bred impassiveness. Mrs Kettering took up a magazine, and Katherine Grey looked out of the window and watched a seemingly endless vista of depressing streets and suburban houses.

Ruth found an increasing difficulty in fixing her mind on the printed page in front of her. In spite of herself, a thousand apprehensions preyed on her mind. What a fool she had been! What a fool she was! Like all cool and self-sufficient people, when she did lose her self-control she lost it thoroughly. It was too late.... Was it too late? Oh, for some one to speak to, for some one to advise her. She had never before had such a wish; she would have scorned the idea of relying on any judgment other than her own, but now—what was the matter with her? Panic. Yes, that would describe it best—panic. She, Ruth Kettering, was completely and utterly panic stricken.

She stole a covert glance at the figure opposite. If only she knew some one like that, some nice, cool, calm, sympathetic creature. That was the sort of person one could talk to. But you can't, of course, confide in a stranger. And Ruth smiled to herself a little at the idea. She picked up the magazine again. Really she must control herself. After all, she had

'Ah!' said Van Aldin unemotionally, 'sometimes I guess I will go to one of these big guys in Harley Street and have him tell me that I need sunshine and change of air right away.'

'Don't be so lazy,' cried Ruth; 'next month is ever so much nicer than this month out there. You have got all sorts of things you can't possibly leave just now.'

'Well, that's so, I suppose,' said Van Aldin, with a sigh. 'You had better be getting on board this train of yours, Ruth. Where is your seat?'

Ruth Kettering looked vaguely up at the train. At the door of one of the Pullman cars a thin, tall woman dressed in black was standing—Ruth Kettering's maid. She drew aside as her mistress came up to her.

'I have put your dressing-case under your seat, Madam, in case you should need it. Shall I take the rugs, or will you require one?'

'No, no, I shan't want one. Better go and find your own seat now, Mason.'

'Yes, Madam.'

The maid departed.

Van Aldin entered the Pullman car with Ruth. She found her seat, and Van Aldin deposited various papers and magazines on the table in front of her. The seat opposite to her was already taken, and the American gave a cursory glance at its occupant. He had a fleeting impression of attractive grey eyes and a neat travelling costume. He indulged in a little more desultory conversation with Ruth, the kind of talk peculiar to those seeing other people off by train.

Presently, as whistles blew, he glanced at his watch.

'I had best be clearing out of here. Good-bye, my dear. Don't worry, I will attend to things.'

'Oh, father!'

He turned back sharply. There had been something in Ruth's voice, something so entirely foreign to her usual manner, that he was startled. It was almost a cry of despair. She had made an impulsive movement towards him, but in another minute she was mistress of herself once more.

'Till next month,' she said cheerfully.

Two minutes later the train started.

Ruth sat very still, biting her under lip and trying hard to keep the unaccustomed tears from her eyes. She felt a sudden sense of horrible

'We should be flattered,' replied the Commissary promptly. 'Let me present you, M. Poirot, to'—he consulted the passport he still held in his hand—'to Madame—er—Mademoiselle Grey.'

Poirot smiled across at Katherine.

'It is strange, is it not,' he murmured, 'that my words should have come true so quickly?'

'Mademoiselle, alas! can tell us very little,' said the Commissary.

'I have been explaining,' said Katherine, 'that this poor lady was a complete stranger to me.'

Poirot nodded.

'But she talked to you, did she not?' he said gently. 'You formed an impression—is it not so?'

'Yes,' said Katherine thoughtfully. 'I suppose I did.'

'And that impression was—'

'Yes, Mademoiselle'—the Commissary jerked himself forward—'let us by all means have your impressions.'

Katherine sat turning the whole thing over in her mind. She felt in a way as if she were betraying a confidence, but with that ugly word 'Murder' ringing in her ears she dared not keep anything back. Too much might hang upon it. So, as nearly as she could, she repeated word for word the conversation she had had with the dead woman.

'That is interesting,' said the Commissary, glancing at the other. 'Eh, M. Poirot, that is interesting? Whether it has anything to do with the crime—' He left the sentence unfinished.

'I suppose it could not be suicide,' said Katherine, rather doubtfully.

'No,' said the Commissary, 'it could not be suicide. She was strangled with a length of black cord.'

'Oh!' Katherine shivered. M. Caux spread out his hands apologetically.

'It is not nice—no. I think that our train robbers are more brutal than they are in your country.'

'It is horrible.'

'Yes, yes'—he was soothing and apologetic—'but you have great courage, Mademoiselle. At once, as soon as I saw you, I said to myself, "Mademoiselle has great courage." That is why I am going to ask you to do something more—something distressing, but I assure you very necessary.' Katherine looked at him apprehensively.

He spread out his hands apologetically.

'I am going to ask you, Mademoiselle, to be so good as to accompany me to the next compartment.'

'Must I?' asked Katherine in a low voice.

'Some one must identify her,' said the Commissary, 'and since the maid has disappeared—he coughed significantly—'you appear to be the person who has seen most of her since she joined the train.'

'Very well,' said Katherine quietly; 'if it is necessary—'

She rose. Poirot gave her a little nod of approval.

'Mademoiselle is sensible,' he said. 'May I accompany you, M. Caux?'

'Enchanted, my dear M. Poirot.'

They went out into the corridor, and M. Caux unlocked the door of the dead woman's compartment. The blinds on the far side had been drawn half-way up to admit light. The dead woman lay on the berth to their left, in so natural a posture that one could have thought her asleep. The bedclothes were drawn up over her, and her head was turned to the wall, so that only the red auburn curls showed. Very gently M. Caux laid a hand on her shoulder and turned the body back so that the face came into view. Katherine flinched a little and dug her nails into her palms. A heavy blow had disfigured the features almost beyond recognition. Poirot gave a sharp exclamation.

'When was that done, I wonder?' he demanded. 'Before death or after?'

'The doctor says after,' said M. Caux.

'Strange,' said Poirot, drawing his brows together. He turned to Katherine. 'Be brave, Mademoiselle; look at her well. Are you sure that this is the woman you talked to in the train yesterday?'

Katherine had good nerves. She steelled herself to look long and earnestly at the recumbent figure. Then she leaned forward and took up the dead woman's hand.

'I am quite sure,' she replied at length. 'The face is too disfigured to recognize, but the build and carriage and hair are exact, and besides I noticed *this*—'she pointed to a tiny mole on the dead woman's wrist—'while I was talking to her.'

'Bon,' approved Poirot. 'You are an excellent witness, Mademoiselle. There is, then, no question as to the identity, but it is strange, all the same.' He frowned down on the dead woman in perplexity.

Chapter 10

On the Blue Train

'DAD!'

Mrs Kettering started violently. Her nerves were not completely under control this morning. Very perfectly dressed in a long mink coat and a little hat of Chinese lacquer red, she had been walking along the crowded platform of Victoria deep in thought, and her father's sudden appearance and hearty greeting had an unlooked-for effect upon her.

'Why, Ruth, how you jumped!'

'I didn't expect to see you, I suppose, Dad. You said good-bye to me last night and said you had a conference this morning.'

'So I have,' said Van Aldin, 'but you are more to me than any number of darned conferences. I came to take a last look at you, since I am not going to see you for some time.'

'That is very sweet of you, Dad. I wish you were coming too.'

'What would you say if I did?'

The remark was merely a joking one. He was surprised to see the quick colour flame in Ruth's cheeks. For a moment he almost thought he saw dismay flash out of her eyes. She laughed uncertainly and nervously.

'Just for a moment I really thought you meant it,' she said.

'Would you have been pleased?'

'Of course.' She spoke with exaggerated emphasis.

'Well,' said Van Aldin, 'that's good.'

'It isn't really for very long, Dad,' continued Ruth; 'you know, you are coming out next month.'